



Yemen

Located in southern Arabia, Yemen was formerly two countries: the People's Democratic Republic of Yemen (south and east) and the Yemen Arab Republic (northwest) were united in 1990.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountainous west with a fertile strip along the Red Sea. Arid desert and mountains elsewhere.



CLIMATE

Desert climate, modified by altitude, which affects temperatures by as much as 54°F (30°C).



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Almost entirely of Arab and Bedouin descent, most Yemenis are Sunni Muslims, of the Shafi sect. In rural and northern areas, tribalism and Islamic orthodoxy are strong and most women wear the veil. Tension continues between the south, led by cosmopolitan Aden, and the more conservative north, though political opposition is now primarily from Islamists. Foreigners are subject to sporadic attacks and kidnappings.



THE ECONOMY

Instability deters investment. Considerable oil and natural gas reserves. Agriculture is the largest employer: qat (mild narcotic), coffee, and cotton.



INSIGHT: Mokha, on the Red Sea, gave its name to the first coffee beans exported to Europe in the 1600s



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Yemen

DATE OF FORMATION: 1990

CAPITAL: Sana

POPULATION: 23.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 203,849 sq. miles
(527,970 sq. km)

DENSITY: 108 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 55%,
Shi'a Muslim 42%, Christian, Hindu,
and Jewish 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 99%, Afro-Arab, Indian,
Somali, and European 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Yemeni rial = 100 fils